

Clitics: Greek

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1 Introduction

This paper investigates the intricacies of Greek clitics, which offer a compelling testing ground for competing theories of Clitic Doubling. In turn, Clitic Doubling provides valuable insight into the correct analysis of clitics more broadly. We critically evaluate three prominent analyses of Clitic Doubling: a hybrid movement and base-generation analysis, a pure Agree-based analysis that dispenses with movement, and a strictly movement-driven approach. Through an examination of both distributional evidence and interpretive properties of clitics and clitic doubled objects, this paper argues for a movement-based analysis and presents conclusive evidence against non-movement/pure Agree analyses. While supporting a movement-based approach, we also acknowledge open questions—particularly regarding the relative ordering of dative and accusative clitics, and whether clitics function as semantically vacuous agreement markers or as pronominal elements carrying meaning. The paper will conclude by discussing future research directions to address these unresolved issues.

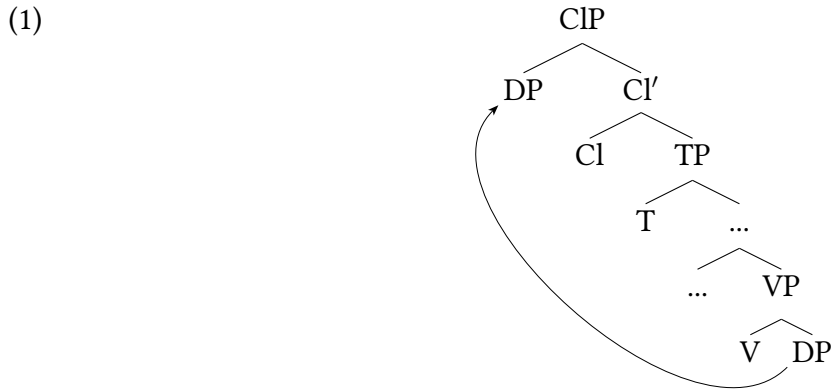
2 Clitics: Insights from Clitic Doubling

This section examines three recent accounts of Clitic Doubling in Greek: movement-based, Agree-based, and hybrid (Agree+movement). While all three assume that clitic-doubled objects enter the derivation as arguments ([Anagnostopoulou 1994](#)), they differ fundamentally in their analysis of clitics; specifically, their position (whether base-generated or derived) and their function (whether they are agreement markers lacking semantic import or contentful elements). We argue that a movement-based or hybrid approach provides a more robust and empirically grounded analysis of both Clitic Doubling and simple cliticization. The discussion proceeds as follows: first, we outline the three approaches; next, we systematically compare how each analysis accounts for distributional and interpretive properties of clitics and clitic doubled objects; finally, we highlight key areas and open questions for future research on Greek clitics.

2.1 The Hybrid Approach

[Sportiche \(1996\)](#), [Angelopoulos \(2019\)](#), and [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#) propose an analysis in which clitics are not moved to their surface position. Instead, they head Clitic projections that are merged in the clausal spine above T. From this position, they establish an Agree relation

with an argument¹ and subsequently attract it into their specifier position. In Clitic Doubling constructions, the clitic agrees with an overt DP, which then undergoes covert A-movement to the specifier of the clitic—a process reminiscent of scrambling in Germanic or Hindi, as illustrated by the direct object DP in example (1). This movement is analyzed as overt movement to Spec,ClP, with the lower copy pronounced, due to the so-called Doubly-filled COMP Filter, which prevents the moved DP from being spelled out in the presence of an overt clitic. In simple cliticization, the clitic agrees with and subsequently attracts a silent pronoun, which is itself a DP. As a result, simple cliticization realizes the same structure as in example (1).



A core tenet of [Angelopoulos and Sportiche](#)'s proposal, which is based on reconstruction of Clitic Left Dislocated objects, concerns the semantic import of direct and indirect object clitics: accusative clitics are pure agreement markers empty of semantic content, while dative clitics have semantic content.

2.2 The Agree-Based Approach

[Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) propose that Clitic Doubling is pure Agree in that a clitic enters into an Agree relation with an argument. This analysis also agrees in two key tenets with [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#): that clitics in Clitic Doubling function as agreement markers, and that they are base-generated in their surface position. However, this approach diverges

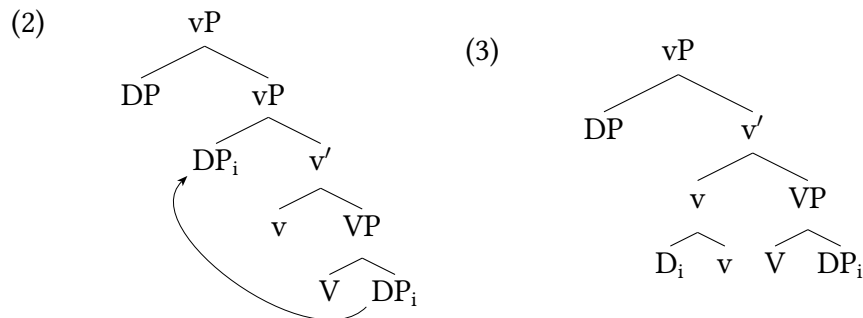
¹ [Anagnostopoulou \(1994\)](#) argues at length that clitic doubled objects are arguments. [Philippaki-Warbuton et al. \(2004\)](#), however, maintain that they are adjuncts, on the grounds that they block possessor extraction, as shown in example (1a), which is typically licit with undoubled direct objects. Their argument is weakened by the fact that the restriction appears to apply only to *wh*-movement ([Angelopoulos 2019](#)). As example (1b) illustrates, relativization of a possessor from a clitic doubled object is allowed.

- (1) a. *Pjanu_i to_j ihe diavasi to vivlio_j t_i?
 whose.GEN 3SG.N.ACC had.3SG read the book
 intended: 'Whose book did you read?'
 b. Idhe ton Chomsky tu opju to_j ihe dhiavasi to vivlio_j t_i.
 saw.3SG the Chomsky.ACC the whose.GEN 3SG.N.ACC had.3SG read the book
 intended: 'She talked to Chomsky whose book she had read.'

from [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#), in significant ways. First, the XP with which the clitic Agrees is not moved to Spec,CliticP; instead, it remains in situ. Secondly, this analysis posits that clitics are not born in a dedicated clitic head. Instead, they are the realization of a second probe on T and therefore distinct from the first probe responsible for subject agreement. The preverbal positioning of clitics and the suffixal realization of subject agreement are attributed to PF-rules. However, the specifics of these rules—how they operate and their exact formulation—remain unspecified. Another difference is that [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#) consider clitics in Clitic Doubling and simple clitics to be the same item, while [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2025\)](#) argue they are distinct but accidentally homophonous.

2.3 The Movement-Based Approach

Movement-based approaches come in several versions, which we do not review in detail here (see further [Anagnostopoulou 2006, 2017](#)). The approach in [Kouneli and Kushnir \(2022\)](#) assumes that the doubled DP of Clitic Doubling undergoes a phrasal-movement step to the middle field along the lines of [Harizanov \(2014\)](#) for Bulgarian. The idea that Clitic Doubling involves movement, whether phrasal or feature movement, has been extensively developed for Greek by [Anagnostopoulou \(1994\)](#), [Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou \(1997\)](#), [Anagnostopoulou \(2003\)](#), and [Anagnostopoulou \(2006, 2017\)](#). Under [Kouneli and Kushnir](#)'s analysis, clitic doubled objects undergo a movement step triggered by an EPP feature on little-v, following [Chomsky \(2001\)](#). Clitics are the Spell-out of a morphological process that affects the higher copy. Consequently, this view does not consider clitics agreement markers. They are instead treated as reduced forms of a contentful D. As a result of the EPP-derived movement, the two copies of the DP form an A-chain. Under normal circumstances, the lower copy of the chain would be deleted at PF via Chain Reduction ([Nunes 2004](#)). In Clitic Doubling, the higher copy undergoes M-merger ([Matushansky 2006](#)) with the v-head.² Once the higher copy becomes part of a complex head, it is no longer visible to the linearization algorithm, as a result of which the lower copy is pronounced. Example (2) illustrates the phrasal movement of the direct object DP. The doubled object, being a direct argument, moves from the complement position of the verb to a position lower than the external argument as a result of [Richards](#)'s (2001) tucking-in. Example (3) demonstrates that the highest copy is realized as a complex head together with v after the application of M-merger.



² The version of M-merger in [Harizanov \(2014\)](#) is not the same as that in [Matushansky \(2006\)](#), even though the results of the operation are.

2.4 The Properties of Clitic Doubling

Focusing on different aspects of the intricate properties of clitics in Clitic Doubling, alongside those of their XPs, motivates the different approaches we discussed. The full spectrum of these properties renders certain approaches untenable, in particular the Agree-based account of [Paparounas and Salzm](#) (2024). On the other hand, we argue that movement approaches to both cliticization and Clitic Doubling fare better. To tease apart these views, we examine distributional and interpretive properties of clitics and doubled phrases. We consider first the distributional properties and then the interpretive properties.

2.4.1 The Distribution of Clitics and Clitic Doubled objects: Part 1

We first consider facts regarding the position and ordering of direct and indirect object clitics in indicative and imperative clauses. Clitics in the indicative precede the finite verbal element, whether it is the main verb or an auxiliary, as illustrated in example (4). In (4a), the accusative clitic *tin* ‘her’ is positioned directly before the finite verb *idhan* ‘saw.’ In (4b), the accusative clitic *tin* precedes the auxiliary *ehun* ‘have.’ When multiple clitics occur, their order is fixed, with dative clitics consistently preceding accusative clitics, as in (4c). Example (4) shows that the position and order of clitics are not affected by whether these clitics are bare or associate with an overt DP argument, e.g., *tu skinotheti* ‘direct’ and *tin tenia* ‘the movie.’

- (4) a. *Tin idhan (tin tenia).*
3SG.F.ACC saw.3SG the movie.ACC
‘They saw her/the movie.’
- b. *Tin ehun dhi (tin tenia).*
3SG.F.ACC have.3PL seen the movie.ACC
‘They have seen her/the movie.’
- c. *Tu tin exun dhiksi (tu skinotheti) (tin tenia).*
3SG.M.DAT 3SG.F.ACC have.3PL shown the director.DAT the movie.ACC
‘They have shown her to him/They have shown the director the movie.’

In the imperative, the placement and ordering of clitics differ. Whether bare or in Clitic Doubling, they appear postverbally and their ordering is flexible. Both dative-accusative and accusative-dative orders are allowed, as illustrated in example (5).

- (5) a. *Dhikhse tu tin (tu skinotheti) (tin tenia).*
show.3SG 3SG.M.DAT 3SG.F.ACC the director.DAT the movie.ACC
‘Show her to him.’
- b. *Dhikhse tin tu (tu skinotheti) (tin tenia).*
show.3SG 3SG.F.ACC 3SG.M.DAT the director.DAT the movie.ACC
‘Show her to him.’

Let us now explore how the three different analyses we discussed can explain the patterns observed in (4) and (5). First, if we adopt the approach of [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#) and

posit that clitics are merged externally above T, the preverbal position of clitics relative to any finite verbal element, be it lexical or auxiliary, follows naturally. Moreover, assuming clitics are not incorporated into the verb, we can then account for postverbal placement in imperatives through verb movement to a position higher than the clitic heads (see Terzi 1999 and Rivero and Terzi 1995 for this line of analysis). To further corroborate the idea that clitics are not syntactically incorporated into the verb, Angelopoulos and Sportiche show that preverbal clitics can be coordinated in disjunctions, as evidenced in (6).³ We also present new data in example (7), which shows that clitics in constructions such as (6) are neither syntactically nor prosodically incorporated into T. Example (7a) illustrates that simple clitics can optionally incorporate into the verb, either prosodically or syntactically, which leads to the omission of the tense augment *e-*. In disjunctions, however, the augment cannot be omitted (example 7b), which indicates that clitics in such cases are neither prosodically nor syntactically incorporated into the verb.

- (6) a. Ton i tin idhes?
 3SG.M.ACC or 3SG.F.ACC saw.2SG
 ‘Did you see him or her?’
 b. Tu i tis tin edhikses?
 3SG.M.DAT or 3SG.F.DAT 3SG.F.ACC show.2SG
 ‘You should her to him or her.’
- (7) a. Ta (e)-fagha.
 3PL.N.ACC TNS-ate.1SG
 ‘I ate them.’
 b. Ta i to *(e)-fagha?
 3PL.N.ACC or 3PL.N.ACC TNS-ate.1SG
 intended: ‘I ate them or it.’

With ditransitive verbs, as in example (4c), two hierarchically organized Clitic heads are assumed to be present above T under this analysis. An open question is whether the order is universally determined (e.g., $Cl_{Acc} > Cl_{Dat}$, as in French) or subject to variation. If there is a universal $Cl_{Acc} > Cl_{Dat}$ order, the mirror order found in languages like Greek—i.e., $Cl_{Dat} > Cl_{Acc}$ —would have to be derived, e.g., via head movement of the dative clitic into the accusative clitic. In contrast, an Agree-based approach struggles to account for the distribution of clitics. Since clitics under this view are T-probes, it predicts that they should always precede finite elements and—crucially—remain adjacent to the verb in T. As a result, it fails to explain the postverbal clitic placement in imperatives, where the clitics are separated from the verb. Furthermore, this approach suffers from a reliance on undefined PF operations to determine the order of dative and accusative clitics.

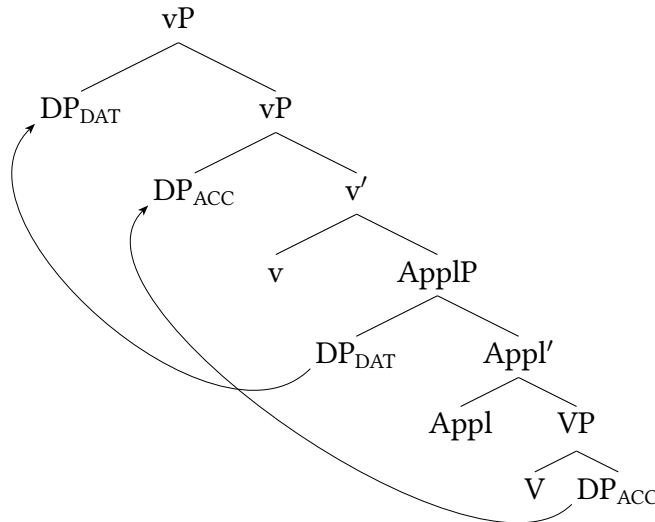
The movement-based approaches of Harizanov (2014) and Kouneli and Kushnir (2022) have to be significantly modified to account for the same facts. Angelopoulos and Sportiche (2021)

³ Another possibility is that imperatives and coordination involve a different element—not a clitic, but a weak pronoun, in the typology of Cardinaletti and Starke (1999) (see also Mavrogiorgos 2010). However, this alternative faces a significant challenge: in Greek, the distinction between clitics and weak pronouns is opaque, as there is no context in which the two can be either morphologically or distributionally differentiated.

and [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) observe that this approach, which derives clitic placement by movement to Spec,vP followed by M-merger, incorrectly predicts that clitics appear with the participle in compound tenses, rather than with the auxiliary. Even if one assumes instead that the DP moves to Spec,TP, in order to account for attachment to auxiliary in compound tenses, M-merger still causes the clitic to form a complex head with the finite verb in T, which entails that clitics always precede the verb. For imperatives, they would have to assume that clitics surface to the right of the verb and dispense with T-to-C movement.

When a ditransitive verb is involved, as in example (4c) above, the ordering of the clitics is derived: in Greek, the dative DP object is merged higher than the direct object DP ([Anagnostopoulou 2003](#); for French they would have to assume the reverse merge order) and both objects undergo movement in an order-preserving fashion, as shown in example (8), as a result of tucking in ([Richards 2001](#); and see [Anagnostopoulou 2016](#) for an alternative that would treat DO>IO orders in Romance as resulting from a nesting derivation targeting two independent probes from underlying IO>DO orders). In languages such as Greek and Bulgarian, this ordered movement, when combined with the subsequent application of M-merger, results in the surface clitic order of dative before accusative.

(8)



Cases involving two clitics in disjunction, as in example (6) above, raise additional questions, however, including whether they involve conjunction reduction or metalinguistic coordination (e.g., *ortho- and periodontists*, [Artstein 2005](#)), why identical constructions cannot be formed with conjunction rather than disjunction, and why they are only allowed with certain clitic combinations. If these cases do not involve conjunction reduction or metalinguistic coordination, they could offer significant insights into the correct analysis of cliticization and Clitic Doubling in Greek. We reserve exploration of these questions for future work.

2.4.2 The Distribution of Clitics and Clitic Doubled objects: Part 2

Recent work has used coordination to distinguish between movement-based and non-movement-based analyses of Clitic Doubling. [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) observes that the first conjunct of coordinate structures can undergo Clitic Doubling, although the second cannot, as shown

in example (9). The second-person singular clitic *se* ‘you.’ can associate with the first conjunct *esena* ‘you,’ and the second-person plural clitic *sas* ‘you’ can associate with both. Crucially, it is ungrammatical for a clitic such as *ton* ‘him’ to associate with the second conjunct *ton Andhrea* ‘Andrea.’

- (9) Se/ sas/* ton idha esena kai ton Andhrea s-tin Athina.
 2SG.ACC 2PL.ACC 3SG.M.ACC saw.1SG you.ACC and the Andrea.ACC in-the Athens
 ‘I saw you and Andrea in Athens.’

Paparounas and Salzmann (2024) present example (9) as a challenge to movement theories of Clitic Doubling. When *se* ‘you’ is used, movement accounts inevitably require movement of the entire doubled DP, *esena* ‘you’, from the coordinate structure in Angelopoulos and Sportiche or Harizanov type of approaches, or extracting the clitic, *se* ‘you’ in Anagnostopoulou or Nevins type of approaches, which violate the Coordinate Structure Constraint (CSC, Ross 1967). However, this conclusion depends on two crucial premises: (i) that examples like (9) are indeed instances of DP-coordination, not clausal coordination; and (ii) that the CSC is an active movement constraint in Greek. Due to space limitations, we assume the validity of the first premise, as argued by Paparounas and Salzmann (2024) (with supporting data not shown here) and focus on the argument that the CSC is an active movement constraint.

Let us turn to their data:

- (10) a. Mazeftikame/ mazeftikate [esis ke egho] s-tin platia apo ton silogho
 gathered.1PL gathered.2SG you.ACC and I.NOM in-the square from the union
 ergazomenon.
 worker
 ‘You and I were summoned in the town square by the workers’ union.’
 b. *Esis_i mazeftikame/ mazeftikate [t_i ke egho] s-tin platia apo ton silogho
 you.ACC gathered.1PL gathered.2SG and I.NOM in-the square from the union
 ergazomenon.
 worker
 ‘You and I were summoned in the town square by the workers’ union.’ Paparounas and Salzmann (2024, (27))

In example (10), Paparounas and Salzmann argue that the use of a collective verb ensures DP-coordination, and the passive voice ensures that any extraction targets the internal argument position, ruling out alternative explanations such as subject island effects. As shown in (10b), fronting the first conjunct yields ungrammaticality, which Paparounas and Salzmann (2024) attribute to the CSC. Similarly, they argue that the ungrammaticality of (11) stems from extraction out of a *na*-clause conjoined with another *na*-clause, again violating the CSC:

- (11) *Oli i fitites_i arxisan [na dhiavazun t_i to vivlio] ke [na meletun oli
 all the student.NOM started.3PL na read.3PL the book.ACC and na study.3PL all
 i dhaskali to periodhiko].
 the teacher.NOM the magazine.ACC

‘All the students started reading the book and all the teachers started studying the magazine.’

However, critical flaws undermine [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#)’s attempt to refute movement approaches to Clitic Doubling. First, their Agree account cannot be extended to simple clitics, which are subject to the CSC. As noted above, example (12a) could be thought to demonstrate that the first conjunct can be clitic doubled, example (12b) shows that simple clitics resist this type of configuration in support of CSC. Under the Agree approach, this inevitably leads to the paradoxical conclusion that simple clitics and Clitic-doubling clitics have a different nature and are accidentally homophonous and accidentally subject to the same clitic placement rules (see further Section 2.5).⁴

- (12) a. Tin_i idha tin Maria_i ce ton Jorgho.
3SG.F.ACC saw.1SG the Maria.ACC and the George.ACC
‘I saw Maria and George.’
b. * Tin_i idha t_i ce ton Jorgho.
3SG.F.ACC saw.1SG and the George.ACC
‘I saw Maria and George.’

Significantly, however, there is strong evidence that the CSC should not be seen as a condition on movement because there are many movement constructions that violate it (see [Oikonomou 2010](#) for Greek and [Sportiche 2025](#) for treating the CSC as an LF/interpretive-constraint, see below for detailed discussion). In Greek, the LF nature of the CSC is evident, particularly in cases where extraction from the first conjunct is possible provided that a specific LF representation is respected. Consider, for instance, the data below demonstrating clear violations of the CSC. Example (13a) illustrates a benchmark ungrammatical example showing that extraction is not possible. Example (13b), however, illustrates that the CSC can be violated as long as the second conjunct contains a pronoun that is interpreted as a variable bound by the *wh*-phrase (see [Oikonomou 2010](#)).

- (13) a. * Pjanu_i thes na djavasis tin diatrivi t_i ce na meletisis ti
whose.GEN want.2SG na read.2SG the dissertation and na study.2SG the
vioghrafia tu Montesquieu.GEN?
bio.ACC the Montesquieu.GEN
intended: ‘Whose do you want to read the dissertation and study the bio of Montesquieu?’

⁴ The claim of [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) that first-conjunct Clitic Doubling is freely available is weakened by their limited dataset. They exclusively examine accusative arguments and neglect dative arguments, which can undergo Clitic Doubling ([Anagnostopoulou \(2003\)](#)). As illustrated below, however, first-conjunct Clitic Doubling of dative arguments is degraded, which contradicts the predictions of the Agree-based approach.

- (1) ?? Tis_i milise evgenika tis Maria_i ce tu Adrea.
3SG.F.DAT spoke.3SG kindly the Maria.DAT and the Andrea.DAT
‘She spoke gently to Maria and Andrea.’

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- b. Pjanu_i thes na djavasis tin diatrivi t_i ce na meletisis ti
 whose.GEN want.2SG na read.2SG the dissertation and na study.2SG the
 vioghrafia tu_i?
 bio.ACC his.GEN
 intended: ‘Whose do you want to read the dissertation and study his bio?’

Building on the view that CSC is an LF-constraint, Sportiche (2025) re-evaluates Paparounas and Salzmann (2024)’s analysis of first conjunct Clitic Doubling in Greek. He proposes that extraction from co-ordinate structures is possible when the extracted conjunct can reconstruct in its base position inside the conjunct. Applying this to Clitic Doubling, he argues that movement of the first conjunct in accusative Clitic Doubling is permitted because total reconstruction of the accusative conjunct is possible, thus aligning with movement-based approaches. This raises the question why the CSC applies to simple clitics, as seen in example (12b). This is immediately captured by Angelopoulos and Sportiche’s finding that simple clitics never reconstruct in their base position.⁵

2.4.3 The Distribution of Clitics and Clitic Doubled objects: Part 3

Anagnostopoulou (2003) and subsequent work that builds on her analysis (Preminger 2009, i.a.) discuss an important set of facts in favor of movement analyses of clitics. The core insight is that Clitic Doubling of indirect objects is obligatory in passives and unaccusatives but optional with transitives. Anagnostopoulou argues that this distribution can be explained if Clitic Doubling involves movement of the dative clitic to the T-domain, which cancels the intervention of indirect objects and thereby allows A-movement of the lower direct object to T across them.

⁵ Note also that Paparounas and Salzmann (2024)’s original data meant to support a movement-based CSC are flawed. Their examples (10) and (11), can be rendered grammatical by manipulating DP type and subject placement. Specifically, substituting the fronted pronoun, *esis* ‘you’ in (10b) with a quantifier or another DP type yields grammaticality, as shown in (1a). Similarly, changing the position of the subject in the second *na*-clause from post-verbal to pre-verbal position, before *na*, also yields grammaticality, as in (1b). Crucially, both modified examples still involve extraction from a conjunct. The fact that grammaticality is restored by manipulating DP type or subject position within the second conjunct undermines the idea that the CSC is a movement constraint. Therefore, first conjunct Clitic Doubling provides no valid evidence against movement-based analyses.

- (1) a. Oli i fili mazeftikame/ mazeftikan [t_i ke i synjenis s-tin platia tu
 all the friends.NOM gathered.1PL gathered.3PL and the relatives.NOM in-the square.ACC the
 xorju].
 village.GEN
 intended: ‘All the friends and the relatives gathered in the square of the village.’
 b. Oli i fitites arxisan [t_i na diavazoun to vivlio] ke [oli i kathijites na
 all the students.NOM started.3PL na read.PL the book and all the professors.NOM na
 diavazoun to periodiko].
 read.3PL the magazine
 intended: ‘All the students started reading the book and the professor started reading the magazine.’

2.4.4 Interpretive Properties: Part 1

Certain interpretive properties of clitics and their doubled DPs are relevant to the movement vs. non-movement debate. One important set of facts is extensively discussed in [Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou \(1997\)](#), namely that Clitic Doubling of objects can alleviate WCO. Example (14a) illustrates standard WCO, where coreference between the pronoun in subject position and the object quantifier is prohibited. However, as example (14b) shows, WCO is obviated when the object is clitic doubled. It is important to note that WCO obviation is restricted to co-arguments of the clitic doubled object. As demonstrated in example (15), Clitic Doubling of an object inside an embedded clause does not resolve WCO with the matrix subject.

- (14) a. I mitera tu_{j/*i} aghapai to kathe pedhi.
the mother.NOM his.GEN love.3SG the every kid.ACC
'His mother loves every kid.'
- b. I mitera tu_{j/i} to aghapai to kathe pedhi.
the mother.NOM his.GEN 3SG.N.ACC love.3SG the every kid.ACC
'His mother loves every kid.'
- (15) a. I mitera tu_{j/*i} ipe oti aghapai to kathe pedhi.
the mother.NOM his.GEN said.3SG oti love.3SG the every kid.ACC
'His mother said that she loves every kid.'
- b. I mitera tu_{j/*i} ipe oti to aghapai to kathe pedhi.
the mother.NOM his.GEN said.3SG oti 3SG.N.ACC love.3SG the every kid.ACC
'His mother said that she loves every kid.'

Movement-based analyses, which incorporate a movement step in Clitic Doubling, offer a straightforward account for both the obviation of WCO in Clitic Doubling contexts and the observed locality of this effect. Crucially, these analyses propose that the clitic doubled object undergoes A-movement to a position structurally higher than Spec,vP, Spec,ClP in (16). This movement is key because it allows the clitic doubled object, from its raised position, to bind the pronoun within the subject, which undergoes reconstruction to its base position, in Spec,vP, as shown in (16). WCO is thus obviated as a direct consequence of the moved clitic doubled object binding the pronoun from its A-moved position (Spec,ClP or a similar landing site) into the subject in its reconstructed position (see [Anagnostopoulou 2003](#)). Moreover, since WCO is alleviated due to movement, and this movement is an A-movement step that is local, it follows that WCO can only be obviated with a co-argument of the clitic doubled object.

- (16) [_{ClP} to kathe phedhi [_{Cl'} Cl [... ... [_{vP} [_{DP} i mitera tu] [_v [_{VP} V [_{DP} to kathe phedhi]]]]]]]

[Paparounas and Salzmann](#)'s Agree-based account by contrast vaguely attributes WCO obviation to information-structural properties. They fail to detail these properties or how they specifically apply to Clitic Doubling and offer no substantial analysis of the information structure of Clitic Doubling itself. Their suggestion that givenness, potentially expressed by Clitic Doubling, plays

a role in WCO obviation is weak. Moreover, not all DPs expressing givenness obviate WCO. For instance, as [Georgiou \(2023\)](#) demonstrates, topicalized DPs in Greek, which occupy the left periphery and also convey givenness, notably fail to obviate WCO with the subject of the sentence, as shown in example (17). This evidence demonstrates that information structure factors such as givenness are not linked to WCO effects.⁶ More fundamentally, an information-structure-based account fails to capture the critical locality fact: a clitic doubled object obviates WCO only with its co-arguments, not with arguments of different verbs, such as a matrix subject, as demonstrated in example (15). Under an information-structure approach, this locality restriction remains unexplained, an accidental correlation at best, given that information structure itself should not be sensitive to syntactic locality if it does not affect the syntactic structure.

- (17) *Kathe fitit_i proselave o pateras tu_i t_i.
 every student.ACC hired.3SG the father.NOM his.GEN
 ‘His father hired every student’

We now turn to Condition C, another interpretive principle that [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) invoke to challenge movement-based analyses of Clitic Doubling. We argue that this evidence is ultimately unconvincing. [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) examine data such as example (18). As shown in (18a), in the absence of Clitic Doubling, Condition C blocks coreference between the R-expression in DP1 and the one in DP2. Since A-movement is known to bleed Condition C ([Lebeaux, 2009](#)), they propose that if clitic doubled objects undergo A-movement, then Clitic Doubling of DP2 should obviate Condition C. Their data show that this prediction does not hold. Condition C is not bled by Clitic Doubling of DP2 in example (18a). They therefore conclude that Condition C undermines movement-based analyses of Clitic Doubling.

- (18) a. *Edhikse i Maria [_{DP1} tu Adrea_i] [_{DP2} tin fotoghrafia tu
 showed.3SG the Maria.NOM the Adrea.DAT the photo the
 Adrea_i].
 Andrea.GEN
 ‘Maria showed Andrea the picture of Andrea.’
 b. *Tin_i edhikse i Maria [_{DP1} tu Adrea_i] [_{DP2} tin fotoghrafia tu
 3SG.F.ACC showed.3SG the Maria.NOM the Adrea.DAT the photo the
 Adrea_i]_i.
 Andrea.GEN
 ‘Maria showed Andrea the picture of Andrea.’

[Paparounas and Salzmann](#) overlook a crucial aspect of A-movement, however. While it can bleed Condition C, it does not have to, particularly in Greek ([Anagnostopoulou 2003](#), 334 n. 70).⁷ This is illustrated in example (19) on the basis of the same contexts used by [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#), where it has previously been argued that A-movement is involved, namely in raising and

⁶ [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024, n. 40\)](#) actually discuss this note in regard to Topicalization, but do not offer an explanation, and leave the issue for future research.

⁷ [Paparounas and Salzmann \(2024\)](#) acknowledge that A-movement exhibits this behavior, but they do not take it into consideration as a possible confound.

psych constructions. The examples in (19) show that A-movement of *i pinakes tu Picasso* ‘Picasso’s painting’ across the dative clitic *tu* ‘his’ does not bleed Condition C. That Condition C is not bled in Clitic Doubling does not preclude the presence of A-movement, given that Condition C is bled only in a subset of cases of A-movement for reasons that have yet to be determined.⁸

- (19) a. [I pinakes tu Picasso]_i tu_{j/i} fenode t_x ashimi.
the paintings.NOM the Picasso.GEN 3SG.F.DAT seem.3PL ugly
‘The paintings of Picasso seem ugly to him.’
b. [I pinakes tu Picasso]_i tu_{j/i} aresun t_x.
the paintings.NOM the Picasso.GEN 3SG.F.DAT appeal to.3PL
‘The paintings of Picasso are appealing to him.’

2.5 Cliticization vs. Clitic Doubling

We have discussed three recent approaches, two of which, the one in [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#) and the one in [Kouneli and Kushnir \(2022\)](#), assume that cliticization realizes the same underlying syntactic structure as Clitic Doubling. This conclusion has been widely adopted in other cliticization theories, such as long head movement ([Preminger 2019](#)), BigDP analyses ([Uriagereka 1995](#)), feature movement ([Anagnostopoulou 2003](#)) and the Q-float analysis ([Nevins 2011](#)). However, as already mentioned, [Paparounas and Salzmänn \(2025\)](#) challenge this view, based on data showing that clitics are interpreted in their surface position (see [Angelopoulos and Sportiche 2021](#)). [Paparounas and Salzmänn](#) demonstrate this point with examples like (20a)-(20b). For instance, (20a) shows that in the base order, a direct object cannot bind a reflexive in the indirect object position. However, when the direct object is cliticized and precedes the verb, as in (20b), the dative anaphor can be licensed (however, see n. 9 and [Everaert and Anagnostopoulou 1997](#)).

- (20) a. *Edhiksa tu eafu tu_i ton Jorgho_i.
showed.1SG the self.DAT his.GEN the George.ACC
intended: ‘I showed George to himself.’
b. Ton_i edhiksa tu eafu tu_i.
3SG.M.ACC showed.1SG the self.DAT his.GEN
intended: ‘I showed him to himself’

⁸ [Paparounas and Salzmänn](#) also present data concerning Condition C, specifically cases where a clitic doubled object is predicted to trigger Condition C in its moved position. Their baseline examples, such as (1), involve an R-expression within DP1 that does not c-command an R-expression in DP2. These sentences are presented as grammatical, but Elena Anagnostopoulou, Nikos Angelopoulos, and seven other native speakers could not reliably assess their grammaticality. Adding Clitic Doubling further complicates these examples, making reliable judgments impossible. They therefore offer minimal theoretical support for the debate between movement and non-movement approaches.

- (1) Edikse i Maria [DP1 tis miteras tu Jorghaki_i] [DP2 ton Jorghaki_i].
showed.3SG the Maria.NOM the mother.DAT the George.GEN the George.ACC
‘Maria showed George’s mother George.’

Extending the Agree-based approach for Clitic Doubling proposed by [Paparounas and Salzmänn \(2024\)](#) to account for cliticization fails to explain the contrast in example (20). If it were to be extended, this theory would posit that the clitic functions as a T-probe and enters into an Agree relation with an in-situ silent pronoun. However, this analysis incorrectly predicts uniform status for the examples in (20). As a mere agreement marker lacking semantic import, the clitic should not be able to bind. In addition, the clitic’s associate, the silent pronoun, remains in its base position.

To accommodate the high interpretation of simple clitics, [Paparounas and Salzmänn](#) pursue a different strategy: they propose that simple clitics are derived via movement, thus they are different from Clitic Doubling clitics which are born as T-probes. However, this movement-based account introduces significant theoretical and empirical lacunae. Crucially, they offer no principled explanation for why the Agree-based structure with a silent pronoun is not allowed in the case of simple clitics. Moreover, the distinction between simple clitics and Clitic Doubling clitics lacks empirical support. Beyond the challenge of postulating multiple, accidentally homophonous lexical entries for all clitics, crucial empirical evidence contradicts this distinction. Simple clitics and Clitic Doubling clitics demonstrably have the exact same form, occupy the same surface position and display identical ordering restrictions across both indicative and imperative clauses, as we saw in (4) and (5). If simple clitics and Clitic Doubling clitics were different items—which Agree-based Clitic Doubling accounts entail—these striking parallels would be coincidental. Conversely, movement-based approaches offer a clear account of the contrast observed in (20). Analogous to Clitic Doubling, movement analyses propose that either the pronoun agreeing with the Clitic head, situated above Tense, or the doubled object itself undergoes movement, whereby it is raised above the position of the dative indirect object. This movement step effectively licenses the reflexive. This approach avoids stipulating accidentally homophonous clitics. Consequently, the contrast in (20) lends movement approaches significant weight against Agree-based analyses of Clitic Doubling, as they need not invoke unmotivated assumptions.⁹

⁹ A further complication arises regarding the data in example (20). The grammatical status of dative reflexives is debated; many speakers find them degraded or unacceptable ([Anagnostopoulou and Everaert 1999](#)). This unclarity weakens the value of these data for either movement or Agree theories. However, it must be mentioned that for speakers who do accept the data in (20), (1) is also accepted, which further supports movement analyses to Clitic Doubling. Specifically, (1) suggests that clitic doubled objects undergo A-movement to a higher position, as movement approaches propose, thus licensing the dative reflexive. To verify this, we tested example (1) with ten native speakers who accept dative reflexives. Using a 5-point scale questionnaire (1=worst, 5=best), these speakers rated (1) as acceptable (Average: 4.4, Standard Deviation: 2). In contrast to our findings, [Paparounas and Salzmänn \(2024\)](#) reports (1) as ungrammatical, but did not present data from judgments from different speakers for this example.

- (1) Ton_i edhiksa tu eafu tu_i ton Jorgho_i.
 3SG.M.ACC showed.1SG the self.DAT his.GEN the George.ACC
 ‘I showed George to himself.’

3 Greek Clitics: Current Status and Future Directions

This section has critically examined three recent approaches to Greek Clitic Doubling: hybrid, Agree-based, and movement-based analyses. We have argued against Agree-based analyses since they fail to account for the surface position of clitics, the ordering of dative and accusative clitics, and WCO effects. Moreover, apparent counterevidence against movement-based approaches—such as alleged violations of the CSC and Condition C effects—has been shown to be unconvincing. Given these findings, Agree-based approaches should be ruled out, along with their paradoxical assumptions, such as the claim that simple clitics and Clitic Doubling clitics are merely accidentally homophonous.

With Agree-based analyses set aside, the central tenet of movement-based approaches—that movement plays a role in both cliticization and Clitic Doubling—should be maintained. However, several questions within movement-based analyses remain open. An important question has to do with the precise nature of the moved element: is it the associate of the clitic, as proposed by [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#), or the associate DP itself, as argued by [Kouneli and Kushnir \(2022\)](#)? Answering this question requires considering several aspects of Greek cliticization: the fact that the verb can be separated from clitics (e.g., in imperatives), their ordering properties in both indicative and imperative clauses, and the explanation of cross-linguistic variation in clitic ordering.

Finally, movement accounts differ sharply on the question of whether clitics can function as agreement markers. [Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#) explore this question in contexts involving Clitic Doubling of reflexives and embedded clauses, but future research needs to investigate more closely the restrictions that arise when different clitics associate with DPs of different values. There is variation among speakers in this regard. For instance, Clitic Doubling of singular indirect objects is generally accepted, whereas some speakers consider examples such as (21a), in which a plural indirect object is clitic doubled ([Anagnostopoulou 2006, 2017](#), [Kouneli and Kushnir 2022](#)), ungrammatical. Other speakers find them grammatical, however. Similarly, speaker variation has been observed in cases such as (21b), where a clitic is associated with two coordinated DPs.¹⁰

- (21) a. Tus_i edhiksa ton pedjon_i mia fotografia.
 3PL.N.GEN showed.1SG the kids.DAT a photo.ACC
 ‘I showed the kids a photo.’
 b. Tis_{i+j} eplina ti bluza_i ce ti fusta_j.
 3PL.F.ACC washed.1SG the T-shirt and the skirt
 ‘I washed the T-shirt and the skirt.’

Some speakers deem sentences in which both coordinated DPs are inanimate ungrammatical, while others do not. If future research confirms this variation among speakers, it would suggest distinct grammars. For some speakers, accusative clitics like *tis* ‘them’ function as base generated agreement-like items, which are capable of agreeing with DPs of different values, as in example

¹⁰ Speaker variation could be related to distinct grammaticalization paths or dialectal variation (see [Revithiadou and Spyropoulos \(2008, 2020\)](#) for discussion).

[Angelopoulos and Sportiche \(2021\)](#). For others, however, these clitics carry semantic features, such as [+animate], which allow them to co-occur only with animate DPs in coordination.

4 Conclusion

This paper presented a detailed analysis of competing theories on Clitic Doubling and cliticization, focusing on the distributional and interpretive properties of clitic-doubled objects and simple clitics. We have offered extensive evidence favoring approaches that integrate a movement component into their analysis. Lastly, we have outlined open questions for movement theories and proposed that Greek clitics may represent two distinct grammars: a Sportiche-like system that includes a base-generation component and a pure-movement grammar.

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